Coconut leaf spots

Farmer Fact Sheet 90

What are they?

They are leaf spots caused by fungi. One is called Brown leaf spot (photo, left) and the other Grey leaf spot (Photo, right). They affect coconut, betel nut, oil palm and other palms.

Damage

Both are more severe on older leaves. But neither is likely to lower nut production. The spots are worse at rainy times of the years, and also where soil conditions are poor. Rain and wind spread the spores.





How do I identify them?

Brown leaf spot: Look for oval spots on the upper surface of older leaves, 10 mm long and 4 mm wide. The spots have a grey centre and a relatively wide dark brown margin. Black powdery spore masses develop on the underside of the leaves. Grey leaf spot: Look for spots up to 15 mm long, grey with a thin dark brown border. Sometimes the spots join together, and sometimes have yellow margins. Tiny black dots in the spots are where the spores develop.

How to manage coconut leaf spots

CULTURAL CONTROL: Leaf spots are diseases of older leaves and not worthwhile controlling, although occasionally they are severe during long periods of wet weather, and/or where palms are growing in poor soil. If control measures are warranted, improve nutrition and growing conditions. If spots occur in nurseries, and these are under shade, decrease shade levels.

CHEMICAL CONTROL: It is very unlikely that fungicides would be needed against these diseases. If they are, use chlorothalonil, copper oxychloride or mancozeb.

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READ THE INSTRUCTIONS BEFORE USING ANY PESTICIDE